language of friendship and were more reminiscent of an older Chinese imperial tradition of managing relations with tributary states.

Yet, with the Colombo meeting of the Commonwealth Foreign Ministers only days away, time was slipping away and the Government of India instructed Sen to proceed to Beijing for the negotiations. India thus lost further ground by conceding the right to determine the venue and agenda to the Chinese side. He was apparently given no specific instructions on India's expectations from China. India continued to see the whole issue as a matter of protocol. Sen was told that his only task was to reach an agreement on the modalities for the exchange of ambassadors and embassies, and nothing more. No substantive matter was to be discussed at all; all such matters, if the Chinese raised any, were to be referred back to Delhi. For good measure, Nehru also telegraphed Zhou Enlai on 17 January 1950, reiterating that the purpose of Sen's journey to Beijing would be limited to discussion on the establishment of diplomatic missions. [30] The Indian negotiator's hands were tied. He would not be able to raise any specific matter of interest to India, nor would he be able to prevent the Chinese from doing so, because India wanted a positive outcome of the talks and could not countenance a deadlock. Thus, another opportunity to review and re-set the strategy and tactics for negotiations, this time over the establishment of formal diplomatic relations, came and went without proper consideration.

The Chinese side handled the issue of recognition and diplomatic relations very differently. Nehru's message to Zhou Enlai led to considerable internal discussion within the Chinese leadership about what India's motives might be. Liu Shaoqi, who was the ranking leader in Beijing in the absence of Mao Zedong (who was away in the Soviet Union), felt that Nehru's response was similar to a message that had been delivered to